himself, has to do with Afghanistan. And, in effect, we have a combination of three interrelated, perhaps inextricably intertwined very serious problems. Afghanistan, the tribal border regions which provide a special set of concerns and difficulties in dealing with that issue and Pakistan itself. And I know you have wanted to address these questions broadly.

I would like just to spend a few minutes doing two or three things: One, trying to bring this committee roughly up to date on what we found were the major problem areas in Afghanistan and the thoughts that we had on what could be done about them, with particular relevance to Pakistan; and in addition I will have just a few comments to make from my own background and experience on Pakistan and the frontier tribal areas to try to respond to both the GAO report, with which I agree, and to your concerns on this.

There is no question that Afghanistan has come to a critical crossroads and that 2 years ago we might have sublimely thought that it was well on the road to some kind of success. Now, after 6 years it is under serious threat from resurgent violence, weakening international resolve, mounting regional challenges, and a growing lack of confidence in the part of the people themselves. The U.S. and the international community have tried to win the struggle, in our view, with too few military, insufficient economic aid, and most importantly, without a clear and consistent strategy broadly agreed among the participants, including both the Afghans, the United States and our international partners.

We now have to deal, unfortunately, with a reconstructed Taliban and with al-Qaeda forces in Afghanistan and in Pakistan, with a runaway opium economy and with severe poverty faced by most Afghans and, indeed, with a locus of central support that comes in an out of the border regions which continues to aggravate and make an already difficult problem extremely hard to deal with. Why is this important? Well, certainly in the words of our report Afghan has been, as Dick has made clear, is a significant national security imperative for us in terms of finding success there. Failure means new threats from Taliban, and particularly from al-Qaeda in a new sanctuary for them, and to our interests in the region and at home.

Internationally it is seen a weakening of resolve on the part of our friends and our partners and, indeed, on the part of our enemies. It is clear that without an overall strategic vision to reinvigorate where we are we will not be able to attain unified or reachable goals or, indeed, as you made clear this morning, Mr. Chairman, to measure any progress. We are in the world if we do not know where we are going, any road will take us there. I think the corollary to that is if you do not know where you are going, any road is a road to failure. These are important points and I believe will be brought home in our recommendations.

The most immediate threat remains the anti-government insurgency that continues to grow and has grown over the last 2 years. Attacks on Afghan military and police forces have surged. There have been some successes in targeting Taliban and the leadership, and our forces continue to show success. But significant areas in Afghanistan, particularly in the south, have been lost to friendly control and remain certainly in doubt and highly contested.

Our allies also believe the mission is failing and NATO members have shown over the last 6 months an egregious interest, in my view, in departing from the scene and in certainly trying to find a way not to move ahead with the kind of progress that we have in mind but to cut losses and to remain static. A failure here on the part of NATO would also damage the future of the organization itself. We see an acute need, thus, for coordination, for military and especially police training, for the need to bring together the government, which is weak and is failing and which has shown much too much evidence of corruption. A sustainable government cannot— without a sustainable government and an honest government there is

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